

A Regime Theory of Joy

This article presents the theoretical framework underlying the M-ZRT and includes a practical example of a session

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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theory I developed independently to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. I propose that joy is not merely a reward state, but an **access regime**. It emerges when evaluative control (Z) is sufficiently reduced and becomes stable only after crossing a threshold of autonomous deployment.

The second contribution of this work is the proposal of a task designed to induce joy.

Originality of the theoretical framework. To the best of our knowledge, this is the first theoretical framework to identify **action coupling** as the primary variable governing access to joy, and to derive from this principle a systematic set of behavioral perturbations designed to reduce it.

Before Beginning the Task

This task involves a transition toward a different brain regime, in which comparison, anticipation, and evaluation temporarily cease to dominate, allowing a mode in which optimization is suspended.

Consequently, simply approaching the protocol as a problem to solve already moves away from the regime it seeks to produce. Constructing a hierarchy has the same effect, because every hierarchy depends on comparison. Asking questions such as "*Which exercise should I do?*" or "*How often should I perform it?*" already recruits the very cognitive processes that the protocol is intended to suspend.

The protocol therefore begins by treating all available options as equally acceptable. Only from this position can the task begin.

Not performing an exercise is not considered a failure. It is simply one of the acceptable outcomes.

Before beginning, it may be helpful to say to yourself once: "**There is nothing to optimize here.**" Treat this sentence as a single local action that requires no verification. Repeating it in the hope of making the protocol more effective would already reintroduce optimization into the task itself.

An attempt to optimize would therefore shift cognitive processing back toward the opposite regime.

With regard to mental activity, it is advisable to avoid imagined conversations. Beyond that, it is generally preferable not to interfere with the normal flow of thought. Simply avoid treating thoughts as instructions that must be acted upon immediately.

Protocol

Do not repeat the exercises excessively.

Several attempts spread over a few days may be required before a meaningful transition occurs. The principal cause of failure is doing too much. Perform only one attempt per day.

The aim is to produce a regime shift. It is therefore normal for the current regime not to welcome this attempt or cooperate spontaneously. For example, when you perform an exercise without immediately checking its outcome, the current regime may generate a strong urge to verify it or, more simply, encourage you to abandon the exercise altogether.

One way the current regime defends itself is by subtly reducing your interest in the exercise. Thoughts such as "*This isn't for me*" may arise. If the goal is to facilitate a regime shift, it is preferable to continue despite these signals, without trying to suppress or analyze them.

The current regime is generally willing to optimize rest, but not to suspend optimization itself. Yet this is precisely what the **M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task)** proposes.

Simply acknowledge these reactions, then continue normally. If the protocol feels confusing, raises questions, or is even somewhat unpleasant, this is generally consistent with the hypothesis that the current regime does not "understand" why optimization itself is being suspended.

Paragraph Fragments

Read a single line, then move to an unrelated paragraph, or expose yourself to small fragments of text that have no obvious connection to one another. Do not deliberately search for an interpretation. If one arises spontaneously, simply move on to another paragraph, sometimes even before it has fully formed. There is no ideal moment to do so.

Each fragment remains an isolated element rather than becoming integrated into a coherent sequence of unfolding meaning.

The Core Task

- Perform a small movement without comparing it to a before or an after. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.

- Perform a small movement while experiencing it as something that simply "happened," as though you were not its author. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- After looking at the time, briefly imagine that a different time appears instead. For example, **11:24** → **7:13** or **11:24** → **14:31**. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- For a brief moment, treat a completely ordinary object as highly important. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- Launch a music video, then briefly look at an irrelevant background detail of the video. 1 time.
- Launch a music video. During the first ten seconds, do not evaluate the media or your reaction to it, and do not adjust the volume. 1 time.

These exercises briefly disrupt automatic action recruitment, temporarily lowering the level of **Z** and thereby increasing the probability of a transition toward another regime. By contrast, if an exercise is performed with analysis, anticipation, or verification of its effects, the brain automatically recruits a different set of action policies, increasing **Z** instead.

Optional Exercise for Walking Outdoors

The Other Side

For a brief moment, let both sides of the street seem equally acceptable. Then continue normally. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.

Rationale for the Task

In *A Regime Theory of Joy*, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant sensation radiating from the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This distinctive phenomenology...

marquée permet, au moins en partie, d'écarter une explication fondée uniquement sur un effet placebo ou sur la simple nouveauté de la tâche.

L'augmentation de la sensibilité olfactive pourrait refléter un engagement accru du système hippocampique. Si tel est le cas, le rôle de l'hippocampe dans la mémoire contextuelle et le traitement associatif pourrait accroître la richesse et la diversité de l'expérience subjective, produisant un éventail plus large de « textures » positives.

Dans cet état, les couleurs peuvent paraître exceptionnellement vives, presque comme si elles avaient une saveur sucrée, les odeurs peuvent donner l'impression d'entrer dans un autre monde, et de petits objets scintillants peuvent spontanément susciter une imagerie mentale particulièrement riche.

This may explain why certain moments, particularly during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are often experienced and remembered as unique.

A common assumption is that the environment itself produces this feeling. The framework proposed here instead suggests that the environment primarily acts as an amplifier of a brain configuration that is already accessible.

In principle, this hypothesis implies that it could be theoretically possible to remain in such a positive state indefinitely.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to **A Regime Theory of Joy**, the principal obstacle to the emergence of joy is neither a lack of reward nor a dopaminergic deficit, but the progressive rigidification of acquired causal chains. Through learning, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This cumulative rigidity is represented by the variable **Z**.

As **Z** increases, it progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and the production of reliable actions. This regime is incompatible with the ease regime associated with joy.

Imagine a desk containing a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits a large network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is typically assigned less value than a computer and is therefore treated as more easily replaceable. It is grasped in a particular way, used while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual location, and often checked afterward to ensure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also linked to object categorization. A pencil is perceived as "just a pencil," whereas a computer is regarded as valuable because of its many functions. Each object therefore automatically recruits its customary meaning together with the actions normally associated with it.

As learning accumulates, behavior becomes increasingly organized around local optimization. Each selected action automatically recruits the next preferred action policy.

The **M-ZRT** introduces brief discontinuities into these chains before they become fully stabilized.

Why the M-ZRT Targets Optimization

Some exercises briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, while others deliberately leave a sequence incomplete. Together, these micro-perturbations are hypothesized to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, thereby increasing the probability that the ease regime will emerge.

Each M-ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a deeply ingrained mode of operation. For this reason, the task is psychologically counterintuitive.

If the exercises are approached too seriously, the brain naturally reinstates comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. From that point onward, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a state compatible with joy, it may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the exercise **"Modify Your Path."**

Under ordinary circumstances, a player in an RPG walks directly toward their destination. In this exercise, they introduce a slight deviation for no particular purpose. For example, they may change direction for a second or casually walk around an insignificant object before returning to their original route.

The primary activity remains moving through the game world. The alteration of the path is the perturbation.

Beginners often find this exercise surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an action sequence that is already underway. Interestingly, many people find it easier to complete a complex task than to introduce a small arbitrary perturbation into an ongoing action. For some, solving a puzzle or meditating requires less effort than walking in a slightly different direction for two seconds.

With practice, however, more advanced exercises gradually become easier as well.

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and performed naturally, they may already have been sufficient to produce a brief episode of joy, or even to open the ease regime.

They can be applied across a wide variety of contexts, and some target the mechanisms of action more directly and more strongly than others.

The broader objective is to maintain the ease regime even in evaluative environments, a problem that the present theoretical framework naturally seeks to address.

References:

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